

The origin and development of Hungarian desiderative constructions

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Hungarian has developed a deverbal nominalization suffix *-hAtnék* meaning “an urge to Verb”:

- (1) a. *Pukkadoz-ik a nevet-hetnék-től.*
burst-3sg.pres the laugh-urge-abl
‘She is bursting from the urge to laugh.’
- b. *Nevet-hetnék-em támad-t, mintha csiklandoz-ná-nak.*
laugh-urge-1sg.poss arise-3sg.past as.though tickle-cond-3pl
‘I got an urge to laugh, as if tickled.’ (lit. ‘My urge to laugh arose...’)
- c. *Ha nevet-hetnék-ed van, akkor csak neve-ss.*
if laugh-urge-2sg.poss is then just laugh-2sg.imp
‘If you have an urge to laugh, then just laugh.’ (lit. ‘If your urge to laugh exists...’)

The form historically derives from the 1sg/3sg potential conditional form of the verb:

- (2) *Oda me-het-n-ék hozzájuk, nevet-het-n-ék velük, de ül-ök és*
there go-pot-cond-1sg to.them laugh-pot-cond-1sg with.them but sit-1sg.pres and
néz-em a semmi-t.
watch-1sg.pres.def the nothing-acc
‘I could go to them, I could laugh with them, but I sit and watch nothing.’

Building on Cushing (1963), Alberti, Farkas & Szabó (2017) and on our own data from the Old Hungarian Corpus (Simon 2014), the Old and Middle Hungarian corpus of informal language (Novák et al. 2018), the Hungarian Historical Corpus (Csengery 2006) and the Hungarian Gigaword Corpus (Oravecz et al. 2014), we trace the development of this unusual nominalization type from the combination of the potential suffix *hAt* + the conditional *n* + the subject agreement marker *ék* into a single category-changing suffix.

By the 1500’s, a few potential conditional forms were used in an ‘involuntary urge’ sense (*ehetném* = ‘I could eat’ or ‘I want to eat’) reflecting a shift from a semanticization of a speaker-oriented boulomaic possibility reading (Kiefer 1981) to a subject-oriented sense. These uses persisted until the 1800’s, restricted to a handful of verbs denoting basic bodily urges (e.g., *alszik* ‘sleep’, *iszik* ‘drink’, *eszik* ‘drink’, *vizel* ‘urinate’). By the late 1800’s, *-hAtnék* had developed a distinct periphrastic past tense that was different from the conditional perfect (*ihatnék vala* ‘I had an urge to drink’ vs. *ihattam volna* ‘I could have drunk’), indicating that *-hAtnék* had fused into a single suffix marking a non-finite verb form. The periphrastic past of *-hAtnék* underwent a reanalysis where the non-finite verb + auxiliary was reinterpreted as possessed noun form + the copula:

- (3) *ihatnék vala* ‘I had an urge to drink’ $\Rightarrow$ ‘there existed my urge to drink’

At this point, -hAtnék had developed into a nominalizing suffix: we begin to see forms in -hAtnék occurring in non-copular constructions, as in (1). However, uses of -hAtnék were still largely restricted to a small class of basic bodily urges.

In the mid-1900's, -hAtnék's productivity dramatically increased, occurring with a broader range of root verbs. This occurs with a few well-known authors (Gyula Illyés, Győző Határ) but also occurs broadly across the corpus – whether increased use of this construction by contemporary writers is cause or effect of increased productivity is interesting for theories of constructional change. We perform a covarying collexeme analysis (Stefanowitsch & Gries 2005) identifying three main semantic classes of -hAtnék forms in the late 1900's corpus: this reveals a lexical semantic expansion of the construction into three main types, as in (4), though not all examples neatly exemplify these categories. Thus, hAtnék can be added to any verb that an individual wants to engage in at the moment (e.g. rosszkodik 'misbehave', barátkozik 'make friends').

- (4) a. basic urges: eszik 'eat', iszik 'drink', okád 'throw up', nevet 'laugh', sír 'cry'...
- b. movement verbs: megy 'go', menekül 'flee', szökik 'run away', csavarog 'wander'...
- c. communication verbs: beszél 'talk', mesél 'tell stories', káromkodik 'swear, curse'...

The expansion of lexical classes permits exuberant constructs:

- (5) pohár-ba-tiszta-viz-et-önt-hetnék-je
 glass-ill-clear-water-acc-pour-urge-3sg.poss
 'his/her desire to clear the air' (lit. 'to pour clear water in the glass')

The analysis also reveals an expansion of the verb types which -hAtnék nouns appear as the complement of, from basic verbs of existence such as van 'to be', megvan 'to be', marad 'remain', hiányzik 'be absent' to verbs of emergence inclusive of a manner meaning such as rájön 'occur to X' (fel)támad 'attack', keletkezik 'come into being', and kerekedik 'arise'.

We provide a profile of the origins and expansion of the use of the construction as the inventory of candidate lexemes occupying its constitutive pieces gradually increases in size. As a shift from a grammatical marker to a derivational suffix, and from expressing the attitude of the speaker to that of the subject, this change also seems to provide an example of both de-subjectivication and de-grammaticalization. This raises questions about the unidirectionality of constructional change.

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